



Lecture 14: Synthesis Solar System in Context, Astrobiology

Planetary Systems

Tim Lichtenberg
Kapteyn Astronomical Institute
University of Groningen

2026



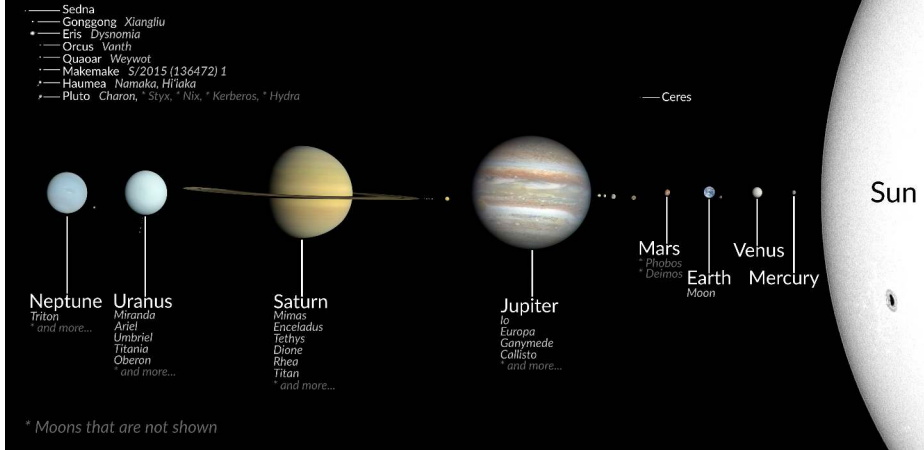
Learning Objectives

By the end of this lecture, you will be able to:

- Place our solar system within the observed exoplanet population
- Evaluate habitability as a coupled *systems* property and derive the classical habitable-zone boundaries
- Identify the most promising life-detection targets for the next decade

Habitability is a trajectory, not a snapshot.

Solar System in true imagery, color and size

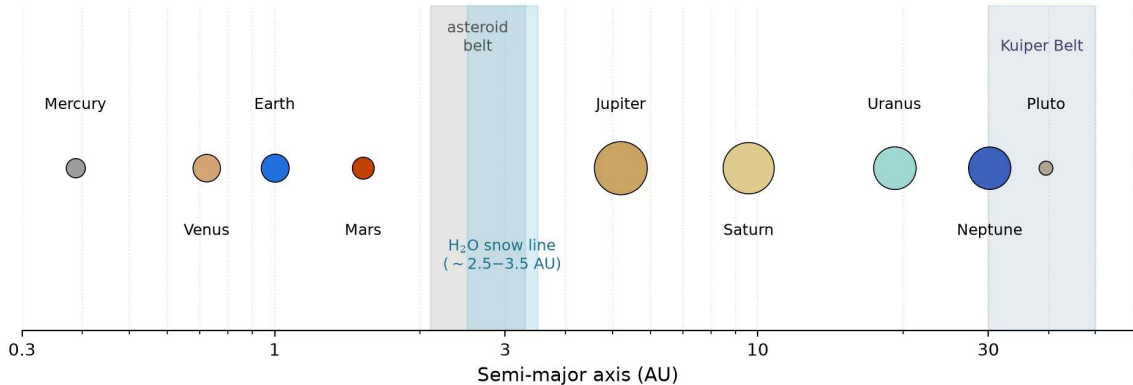


The principal bodies of the solar system grouped by region at true relative size, from the terrestrial planets to the Kuiper belt objects. Credit: CactiStaccingCrane (Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0); NASA/ESA/ISRO.

The Thread of the Course

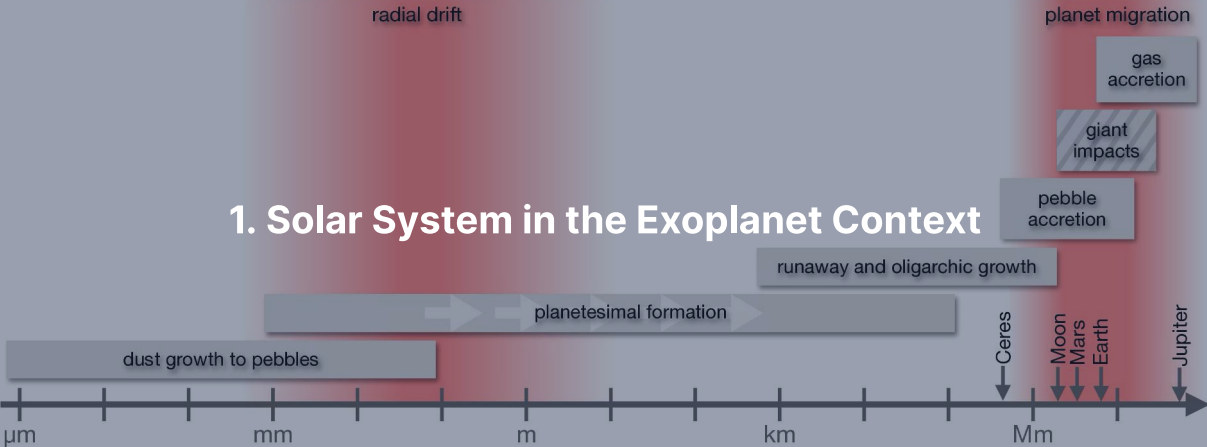
- L1–L8: accretion, differentiation, internal heat engines, and atmosphere-surface coupling
- L9–L12: terrestrial and giant planet evolution traced body by body
- L13: over 6000 exoplanets revealing architectural diversity

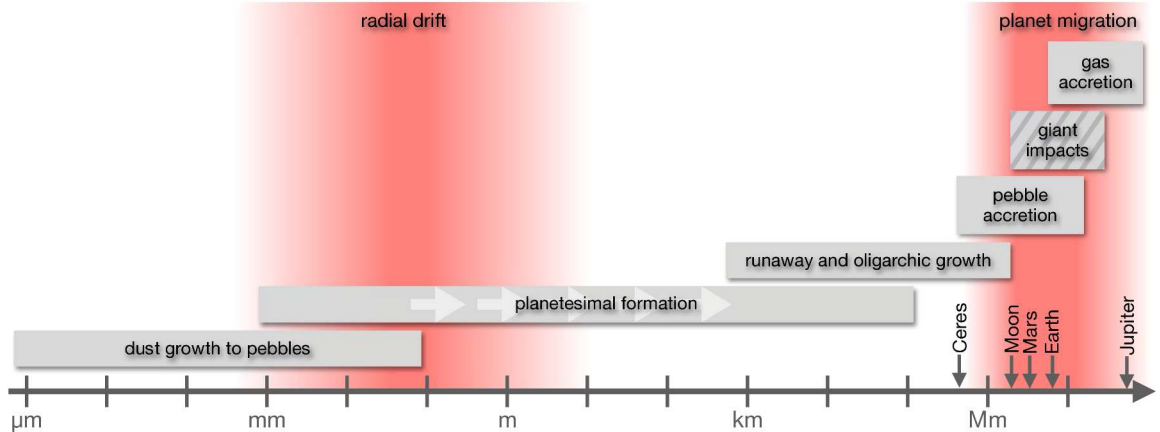
Today: Step back to evaluate the solar system in context and test astrobiological habitability.



Architecture of the solar system on a logarithmic semi-major axis scale with symbol area scaled to radius; shaded spans mark the asteroid belt, the Kuiper belt and the water snow line region. Credit: Course-original figure; NASA NSSDC.

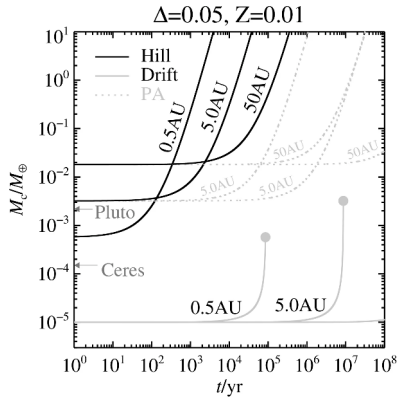
1. Solar System in the Exoplanet Context





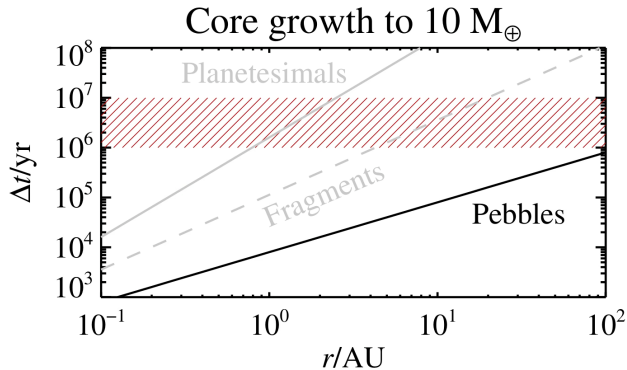
Growth processes from dust to planets. Reproduced from Drążkowska et al. (2023).

Dust grows to pebbles, planetesimals and embryos by streaming instability, pebble accretion and runaway envelope accretion; the disk lifetime of 3–5 Myr is the deadline, and ALMA disk substructure is direct observational input.



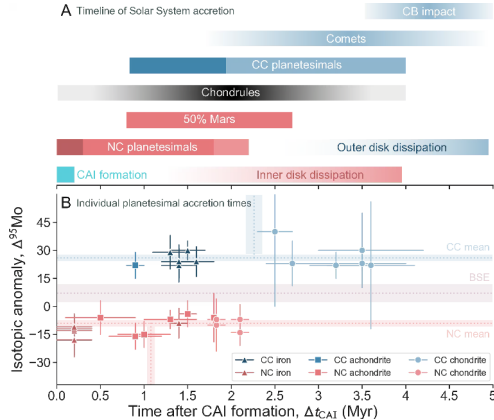
Core mass against time at 0.5, 5 and 50 AU: pebble accretion (solid) against classical planetesimal accretion (grey dotted), with Ceres and Pluto marked. Reproduced from Lambrechts & Johansen (2012).

Pebble accretion reaches 10 Earth masses well within a typical disk lifetime; planetesimal accretion at 5 AU takes longer than the disk lives.



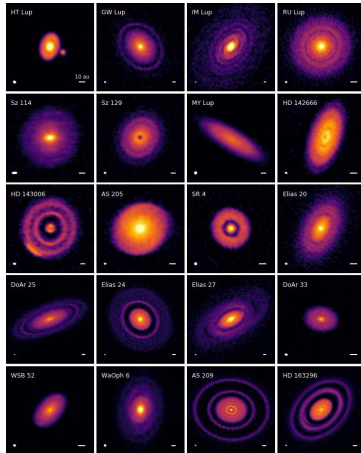
Time to grow a 10 Earth mass core against distance from the star by pebble accretion (black), planetesimal accretion (grey) and fragment accretion (dashed grey); the hatched band is the 1 to 10 Myr gas dispersal. Reproduced from Lambrechts & Johansen (2012).

A core that is to capture an envelope must reach 10 Earth masses before the gas goes: the pebble line stays below the band at every radius, the planetesimal line rises through it within a few AU.



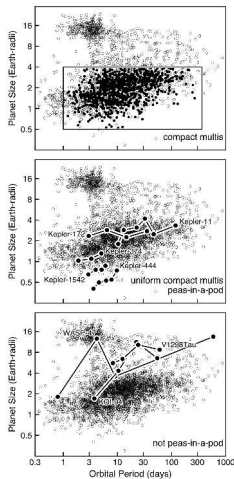
Timeline of solar system formation from isotopic dating of meteorites: the non-carbonaceous (NC, red) and carbonaceous (CC, blue) reservoirs. Reproduced from Lichtenberg et al. (2023).

The two reservoirs keep distinct isotopic signatures from CAI formation onward, so they accreted in physically separated regions of the disk for at least the first 2 to 3 Myr.



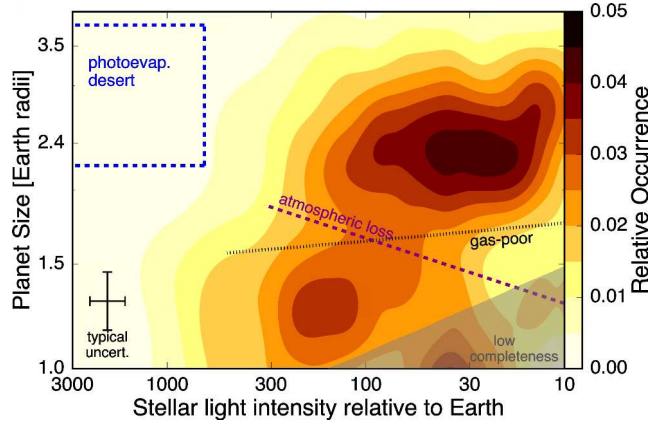
ALMA DSHARP 240 GHz continuum images of 20 nearby disks. Reproduced from Andrews et al. (2018).

Concentric rings, gaps and asymmetries are nearly ubiquitous, and most are interpreted as signatures of planet growth in progress.



Transiting census with compact multi-planet systems boxed: five uniform ones (middle), three non-uniform ones (bottom). Weiss et al. (2023, PPVII).

Compact multi-planet systems show striking architectural uniformity.

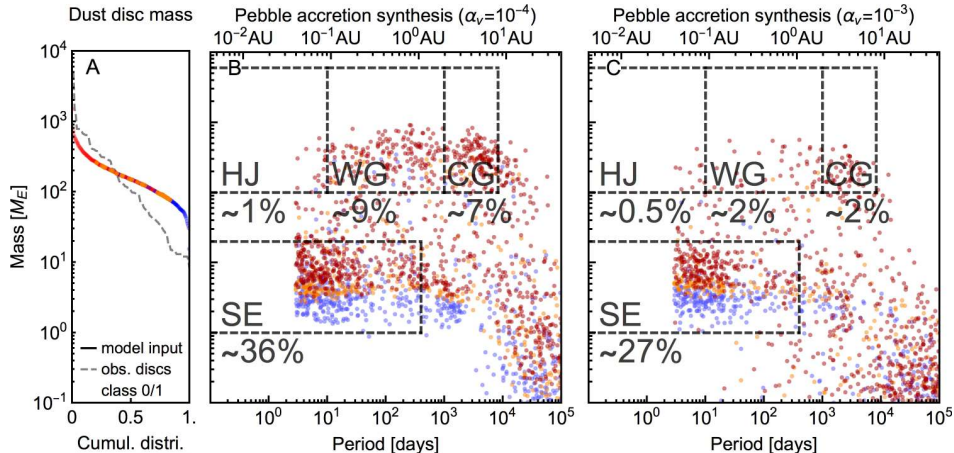


The Fulton gap: planet size against incident stellar flux for small close-in exoplanets, with the deficit near $1.8 R_{\oplus}$ between super-Earths and sub-Neptunes; the lower panel overlays photoevaporation models. Reproduced from Fulton et al. (2017).

Photoevaporation models reproduce both the location and the slope of the valley with irradiation.

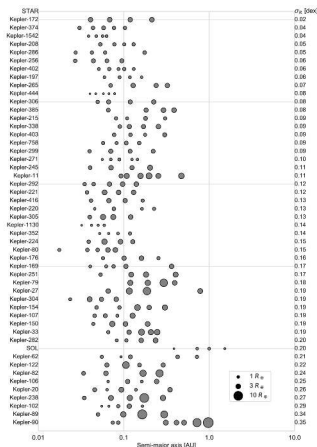
Where the Solar System is Atypical

- No super-Earths or sub-Neptunes: the most common exoplanet size class is absent
- No close-in giant planets: hot Jupiters orbit $\sim 0.5\text{--}1\%$ of Sun-like stars, hot Neptunes are rarer still
- Outer giants on wide, circular orbits, while the inner terrestrials lack compact uniformity



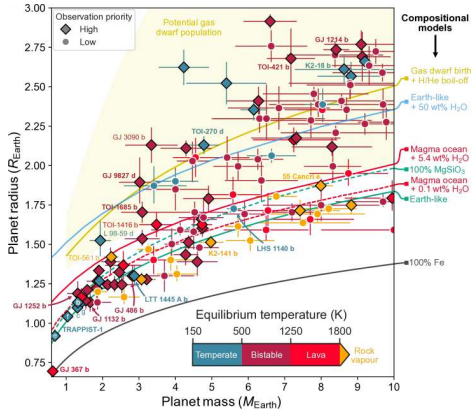
Population synthesis predictions for planet mass against orbital period under planetesimal and pebble accretion. Credit: Drążkowska et al. (2023).

Both pathways readily form super-Earths and close-in giants that the solar system lacks.



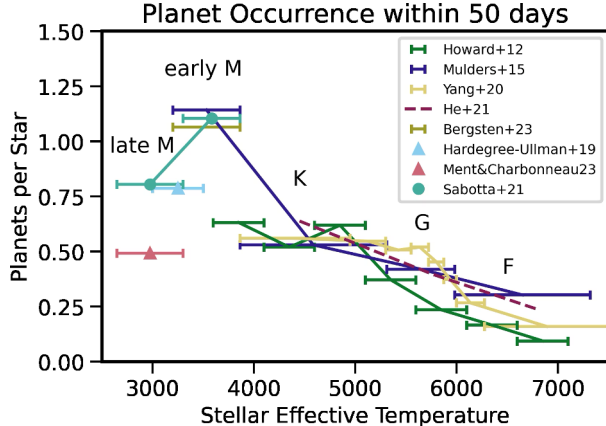
Compact multi-systems with at least four transiting planets within 1.52 AU, ranked by the uniformity of their planet sizes. Reproduced from Weiss et al. (2023).

The solar system falls in the bottom quintile of size uniformity: the inner solar system did not produce the typical compact-multi architecture.



Mass-radius diagram with composition tracks: pure Fe, Earth-like, MgSiO_3 , water-rich, magma plus H_2O , and gas dwarf. Lichtenberg et al. (2025).

The solar system terrestrials and the close-in super-Earths sit on the Earth-like curve, the latter as stripped cores that lost their gas envelopes; larger planets carry volatile envelopes that swell their radii.



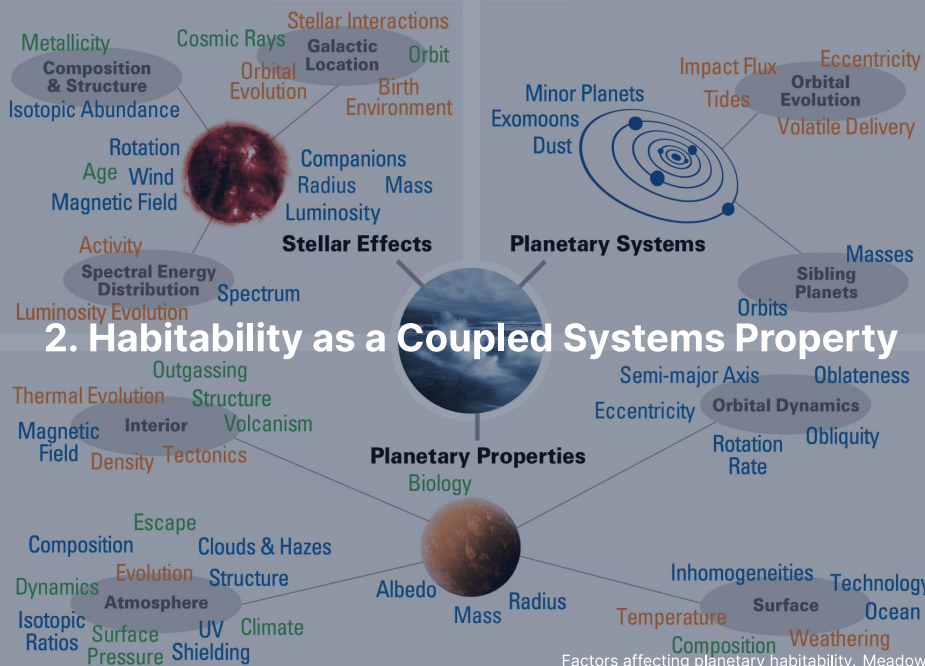
Occurrence of small planets ($1-4 R_{\oplus}$, $P < 50$ d) per star against stellar effective temperature. Mulders (2024).

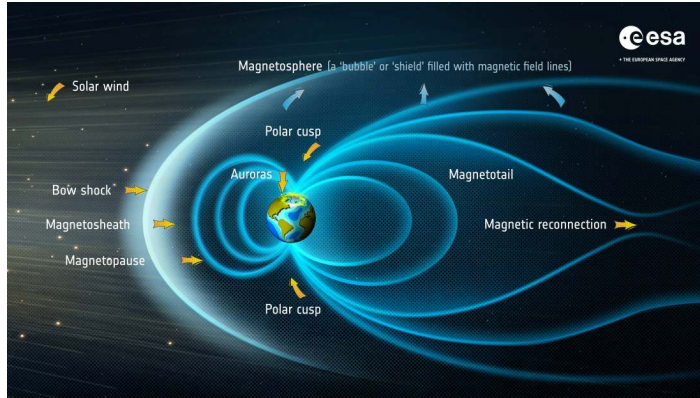
Occurrence is roughly twice as high around early M dwarfs as around F dwarfs and keeps rising into the late M dwarfs: Earth-sized planets are common around the most numerous stars.



The Milky Way over the ELT site. Credit: C. Letelier/ESO.

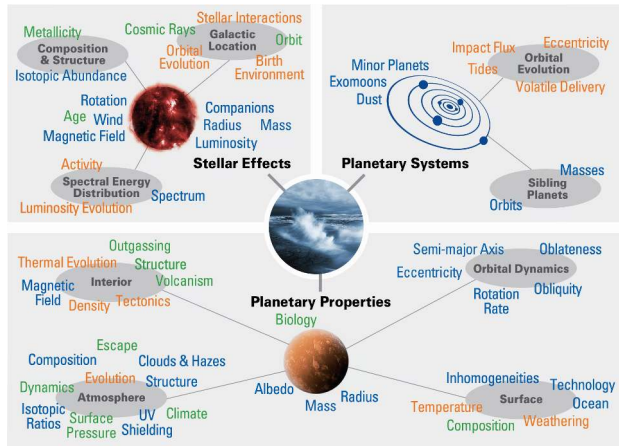
Whether our architecture is rare stays open: 1 AU terrestrial analogues sit at the survey detection limits, Kepler's four-year baseline limited the reach to long periods, and PLATO (2027) and Gaia DR4 (late 2026) will resolve the true occurrence.





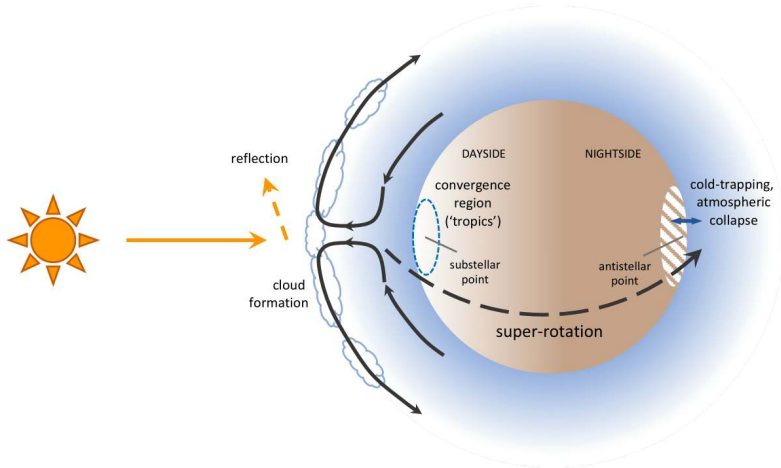
Anatomy of Earth's magnetosphere, one output of the geophysical engine. Credit: ESA, CC BY-SA 3.0 IGO.

Habitability is a coupled stack, not a checklist: a stable, benign star and orbit; a geophysical engine that drives a dynamo and recycles volatiles; an atmosphere that keeps surface water liquid; a biosphere that feeds back on weathering and redox.



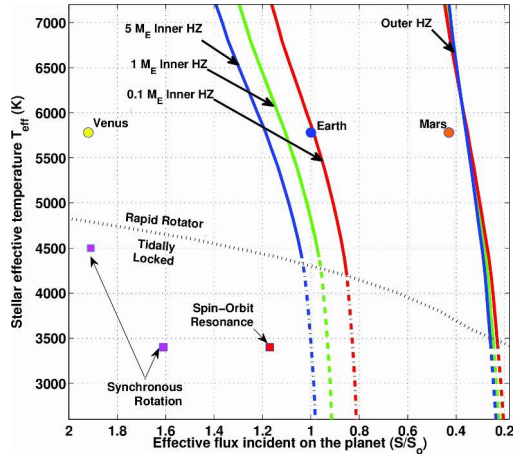
Factors affecting habitability: stellar, planetary and orbital properties jointly shape the surface environment; blue observable, green model-interpreted, orange theoretical. Meadows & Barnes (2018).

Breaking any one of these couplings can end surface water stability.



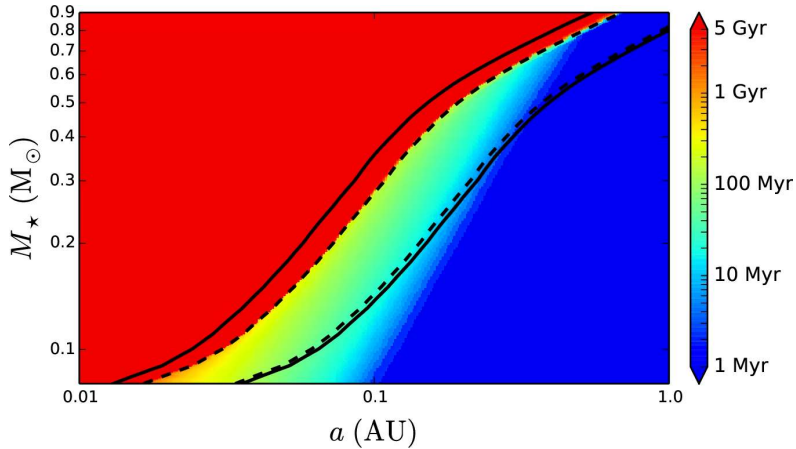
Atmospheric circulation on a tidally locked rocky planet: substellar convection and equatorial super-rotation transport heat. Wordsworth & Kreidberg (2022).

Nightside cold traps risk atmospheric collapse.



Habitable zone limits against stellar effective temperature. Kopparapu et al. (2014).

Inner edge: the runaway greenhouse limit; outer edge: the maximum CO_2 greenhouse; stars brighten over their main-sequence lifetime, so orbiting in the zone today does not guarantee a habitable history.



Duration of the runaway greenhouse phase on a water-bearing planet against stellar mass.
Luger & Barnes (2015).

Late M dwarfs spend up to a Gyr in the pre-main-sequence runaway: the planet starts *inside* the runaway zone and loses its initial water inventory.

3. Magma Oceans, Water Delivery, Tectonic Thermostat

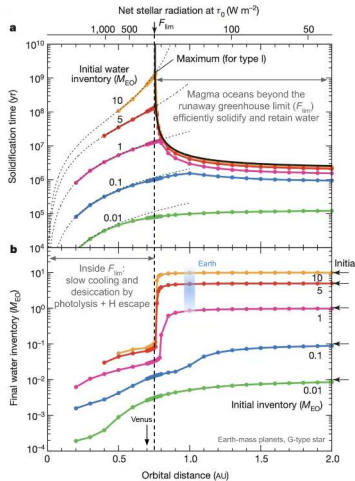


Magma-ocean differentiation. Lichtenberg et al. (2023)

Why "Delivery" Isn't the Right Frame

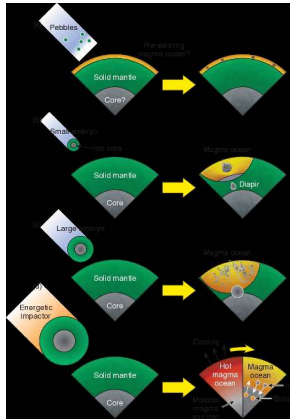
- Earth, Venus, and Mars received similar initial accreted volatile budgets
- Magma ocean partitioning sets the core, mantle, and steam atmosphere reservoirs
- Evolutionary controls: early hydrodynamic escape, mantle outgassing, and stellar brightening

Terrestrial volatile inventories diverge because differentiation and evolution matter far more than initial delivery.



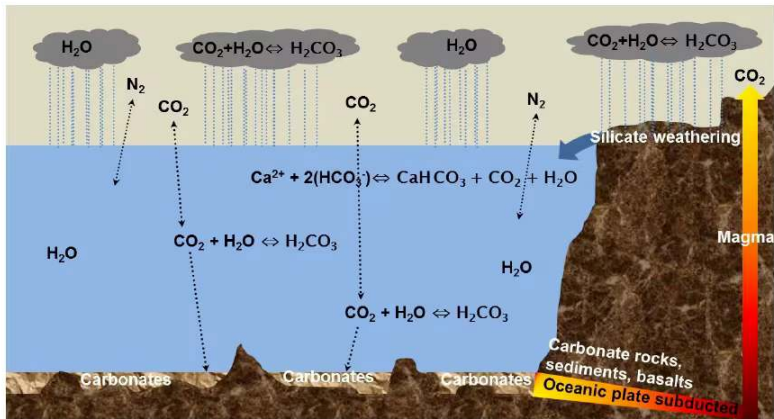
Two types of terrestrial planet from magma ocean evolution. Credit: Hamano et al. (2013).

Inside the critical flux, Type II planets lose their water to hydrodynamic escape before solidifying; Type I planets further out solidify quickly and retain oceans.



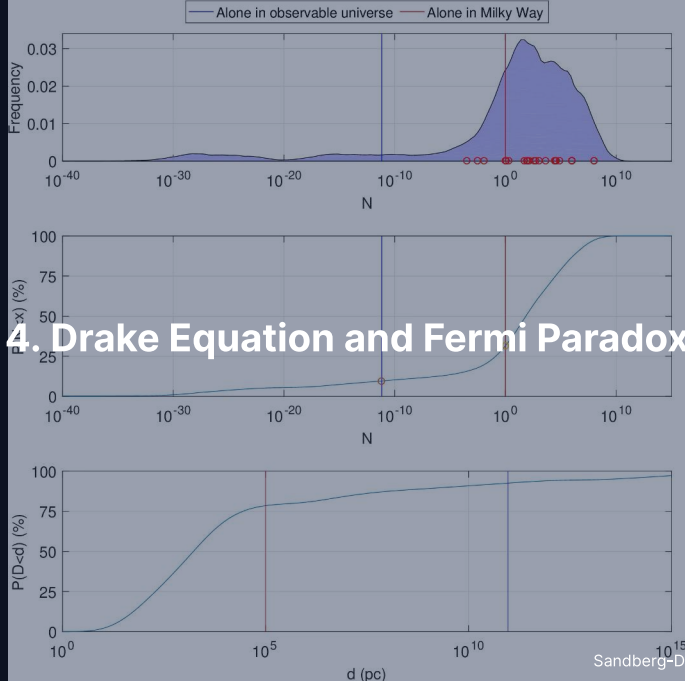
Magma ocean differentiation into a metal core, a silicate mantle and a steam atmosphere.
Lichtenberg et al. (2023).

Volatiles partition between liquid silicate and the steam atmosphere; the sequestered fraction depends on mantle redox, solidification time and depth, so identical initial budgets yield radically different atmospheric masses.



The carbonate-silicate cycle. Credit: Lammer et al. (2018).

Volcanic CO_2 outgassing is balanced by temperature-dependent silicate weathering and subduction, a negative feedback that needs surface liquid water, active volcanism and tectonic recycling; its failure produces the Venus-like 92 bar.



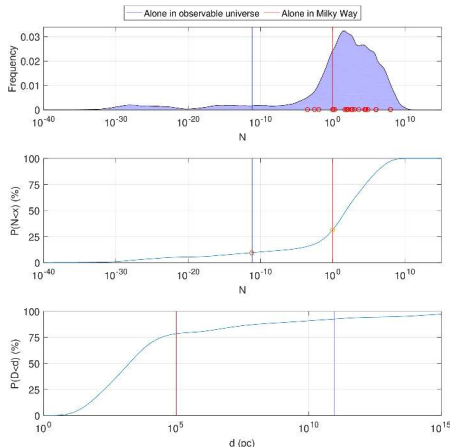
The Drake Equation: A Framing Tool

$$N = R_{\star} \cdot f_p \cdot n_e \cdot f_l \cdot f_i \cdot f_c \cdot L$$

$R_{\star}$ star-formation rate, f_p fraction with planets, n_e habitable planets per system, f_l life, f_i intelligence, f_c communication, L lifetime of a signalling civilisation.

- Astrophysical factors are now measured: $R_{\star}, f_p \sim 1, n_e \approx 0.1\text{--}0.6$ (Bryson+ 2021)
- Biological and social terms (f_l, f_i, f_c, L) span 4–10 orders of magnitude
- Factors co-evolve rather than acting as independent pipeline stages

The Drake equation is a tool for framing ignorance, not a numerical estimator.



Monte Carlo posterior for the number N of communicating civilisations, sampled over the full published parameter ranges. Sandberg, Drexler & Ord (2018).

The distribution is *bimodal*, with substantial probability below $N = 1$ in the Milky Way: the apparent cosmic silence is unsurprising once the priors are honest.

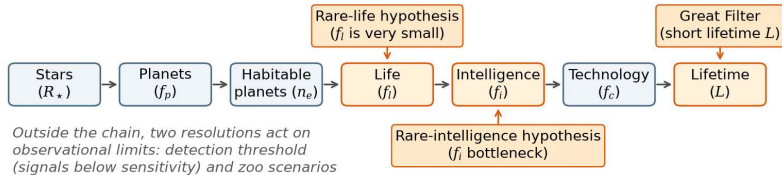
Why Bimodal? Log-Sum of Broad Priors

Taking the logarithm turns the Drake product into a sum of broad priors:

$$\log_{10} N = \log_{10}(R_* f_p n_e) + \log_{10} f_l + \log_{10} f_i + \log_{10} f_c + \log_{10} L$$

- Unconstrained factors have log-uniform priors spanning many decades
- The log-sum of broad, skewed priors spreads $\log N$ over tens of decades; the long low tail of f_l makes the result bimodal
- The posterior spans ~ 30 decades, placing high probability on $N < 1$

(a) Drake-equation filter chain and proposed resolutions (schematic)



(b) Galactic crossing time versus galaxy age (schematic)



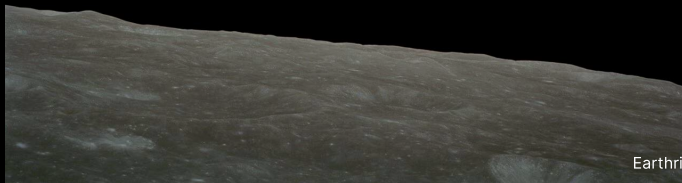
The Fermi paradox as a chain of filters, with a galactic crossing of 10^6 to 10^7 yr against a 10^{10} yr galaxy age. Course figure.

The silence is an intuition check on subjective priors, not physical evidence: rare abiogenesis or intelligence, a Great Filter that keeps L short, or transmissions below current detection limits.

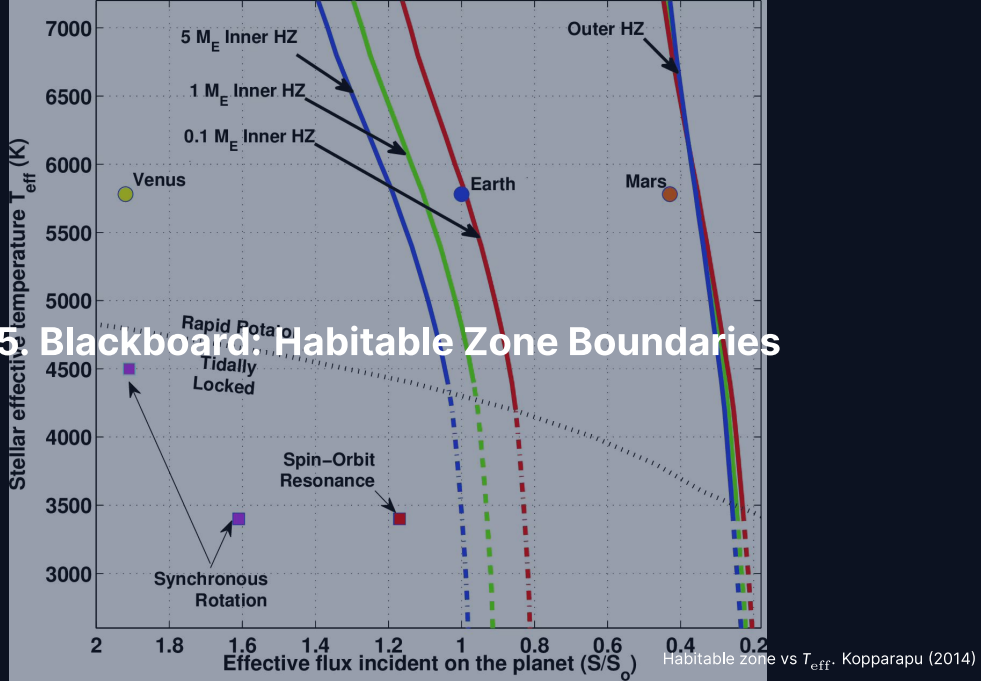
Break



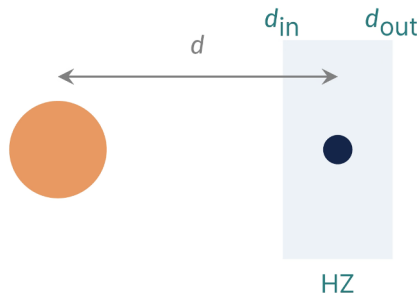
End of Part 1: Solar System Context and Habitability
Part 2: Habitable Zone Derivation, Astrobiology, Life Detection



5. Blackboard: Habitable Zone Boundaries



Goal and strategy



Goal: locate the inner and outer edges of the habitable zone from one energy balance.

- Inverse square in, Stefan-Boltzmann out: $T_{\text{eq}}(d)$
- Express the boundaries as an effective flux S_{eff}
- Insert the runaway limit (Lecture 9) and the maximum CO_2 greenhouse

Star L_* , planet at d with Bond albedo A_B : the zone is the strip between d_{in} and d_{out} .

Setup: Stellar Flux and Equilibrium Temperature

Star with bolometric luminosity L_* , planet at distance d :

$$F_*(d) = \frac{L_*}{4\pi d^2}$$

Bond albedo A_B (reflected fraction), rapidly rotating sphere, equilibrium:

$$T_{\text{eq}}(d) = \left[\frac{L_*(1 - A_B)}{16\pi\sigma\epsilon d^2} \right]^{1/4}$$

For Earth: $A_B = 0.3$, $\epsilon = 1$, $L_* = L_\odot$, $d = 1 \text{ AU} \rightarrow T_{\text{eq}} \approx 255 \text{ K}$; the surface is 288 K from $\sim 33 \text{ K}$ greenhouse warming. *To the board.*

Result: Habitable Zone Boundaries

Effective flux $S_{\text{eff}} = F_{\star}(d)/S_{\oplus}$ and the boundary distances:

$$d = 1 \text{ AU} \sqrt{\frac{L_{\star}/L_{\odot}}{S_{\text{eff}}}}$$

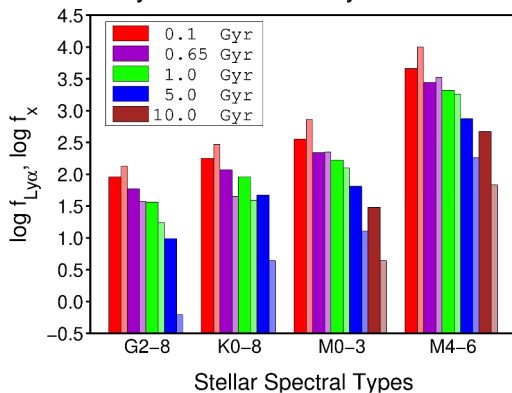
- Inner edge: runaway greenhouse (Simpson-Nakajima, Lecture 9), $S_{\text{in}} \approx 1.06$, ≈ 0.97 AU for the Sun
- Outer edge: maximum CO₂ greenhouse, $S_{\text{out}} \approx 0.35$, ~ 1.69 AU for the Sun
- Main-sequence lifetime $t_{\text{MS}} \approx 10 \text{ Gyr} (M_{\star}/M_{\odot})^{-2.5}$ sets how long the zone lasts

HZ Across Stellar Types

Habitable zone distance scales with stellar luminosity: $d \propto \sqrt{L_{\star}}$.

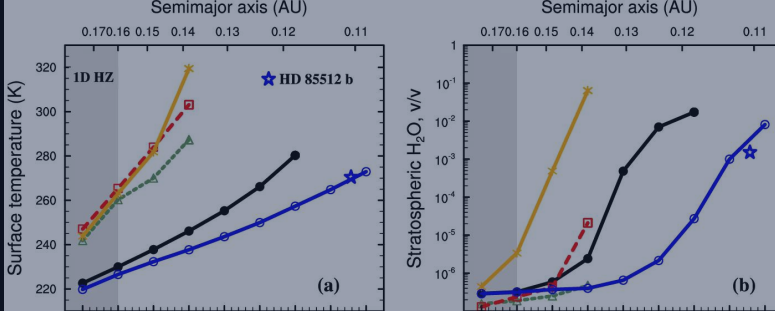
- **G dwarf** ($L_{\odot}$): $d = 0.97\text{--}1.69$ AU; main-sequence lifetime ~ 10 Gyr
- **K dwarf** ($0.3 L_{\odot}$): $d = 0.53\text{--}0.93$ AU; lifetime 24 Gyr (orange-dwarf sweet spot)
- **M dwarf** ($5 \times 10^{-4} L_{\odot}$): $d = 0.022\text{--}0.038$ AU; lifetime 10^{12} yr, but tidally locked with a long pre-MS runaway

Lyman- α and X-ray Irradiance

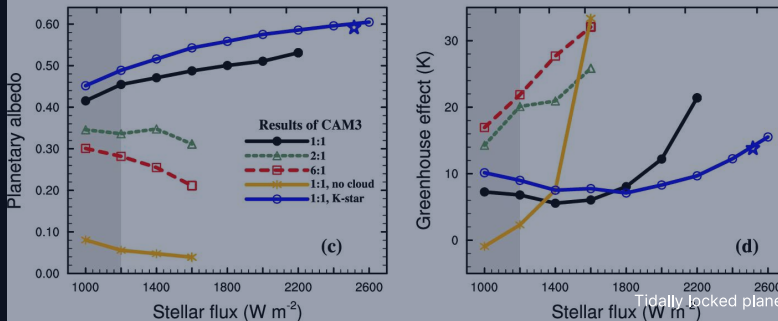


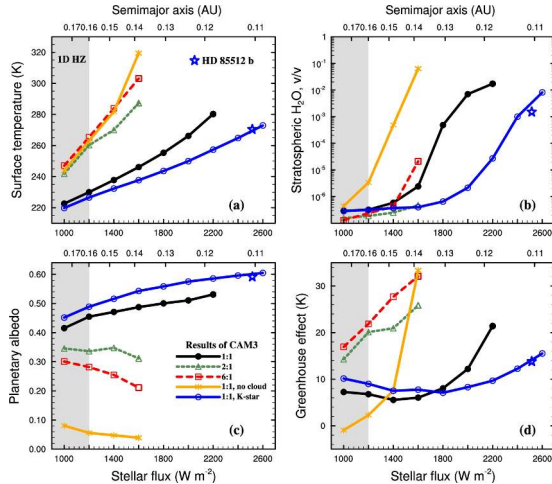
Lyman- α and X-ray fluxes at the Earth-equivalent distance against stellar type and age. Cuntz & Guinan (2016).

M dwarfs deliver over 100 to 500 times the G-dwarf flux; X-rays drop 500-fold over 5 Gyr but Lyman- α only 5 to 10-fold, so early K dwarfs offer long lifetimes without the M-dwarf XUV extremes.



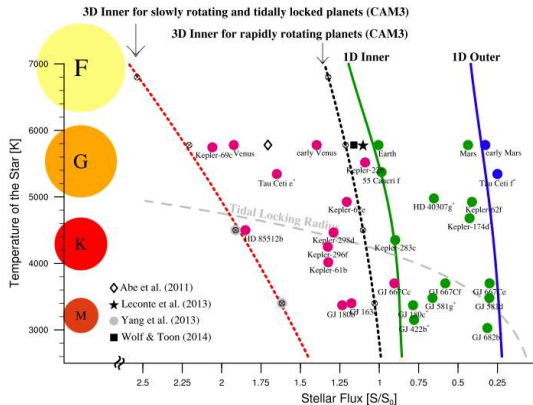
6. HZ Corrections: 3D Climate, Tidal Locking





3D global climate model of a tidally locked planet with clouds. Yang et al. (2013).

Persistent substellar convection lifts thick water clouds, the planetary albedo rises to ~ 0.6 , and the inner edge tolerates $\sim 2\times$ the flux that 1D models predict.



Habitable-zone limits for M dwarfs with stellar flux increasing to the left: 1D Kopparapu boundaries (solid), the 3D inner edge (red dotted) and the tidal-locking radius (grey dashed).
Shields et al. (2016).

The 3D inner edge tolerates 1.7–2.2× the 1D flux, and the tidal-locking radius encloses almost all M-dwarf habitable-zone planets.

Tidal-Locking Timescale

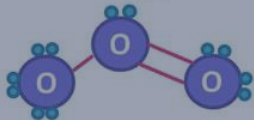
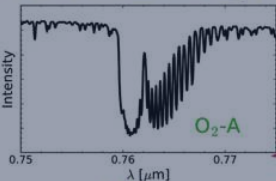
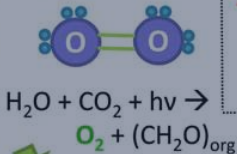
Tidal despinning scales steeply as a^6 , so close-in habitable planets around low-mass stars synchronise quickly:

$$\tau_{\text{lock}} \sim \frac{\omega_0 a^6 I_p Q_p}{3 G M_{\star}^2 k_{2,p} R_p^5}$$

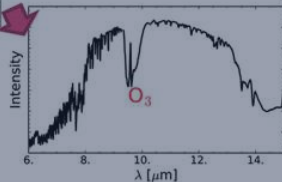
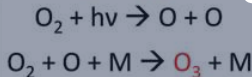
- Earth at 1 AU has $\tau_{\text{lock}} \sim 10^{12}$ yr, far exceeding the age of the universe
- TRAPPIST-1 b ($a \approx 0.011$ AU) synchronises in $\lesssim 10^7$ yr
- With a system age of ~ 8 Gyr, all known M-dwarf HZ worlds are locked

Gaseous

Ex: **Oxygenic Photosynthesis**



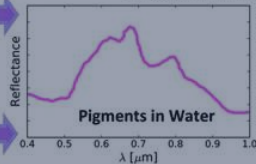
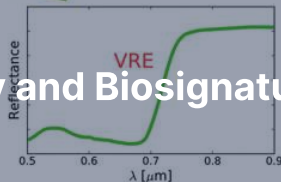
7. Astrobiology and Biosignatures



Surface



$$\text{NDVI} = \frac{\text{IR} - \text{VIS}}{\text{IR} + \text{VIS}}$$



Temporal



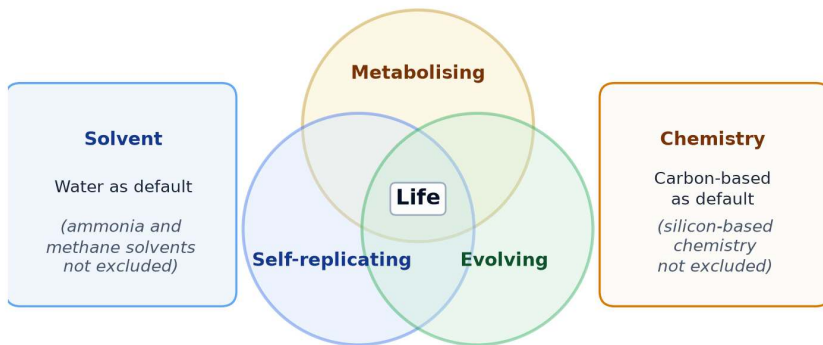
Seasonal changes in Gases or Surface



Origin-of-Life Hypotheses

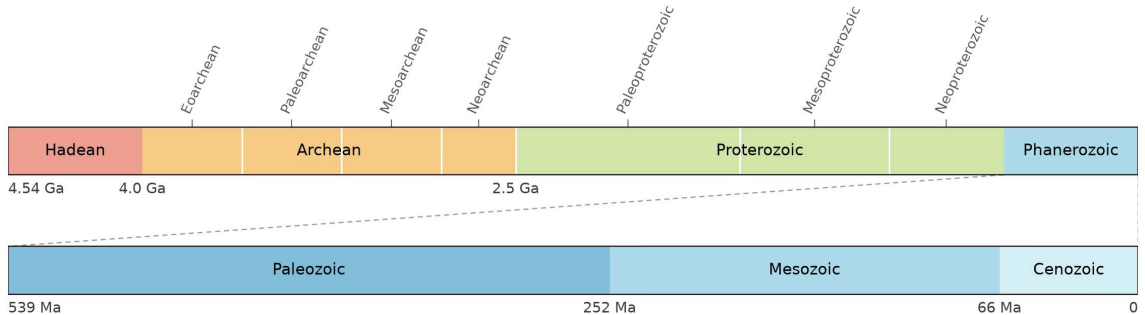
- **RNA world:** catalytic ribozymes carry the genetic code before proteins
- **Alkaline hydrothermal vents:** geochemical proton gradients drive early metabolism
- **Warm surface ponds,** where wet-dry cycles polymerise organic precursors, and **panspermia,** the transfer of viable organisms between bodies

Working definition of life (schematic)



Working definition of life, with water and carbon as defaults and other solvents and chemistries not excluded. Course figure.

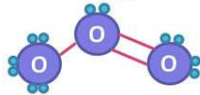
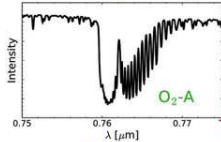
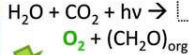
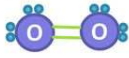
Life (Lederberg 1965): a self-replicating, metabolising, evolving chemical system.



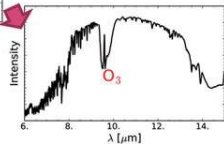
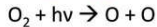
Geologic eons and eras of Earth across 4.54 Gyr: the Precambrian occupies almost 90% of the timeline, with life emerging early in the Archean. Credit: Course-original figure; Gradstein et al. (2020).

Gaseous

Ex: **Oxygenic Photosynthesis**



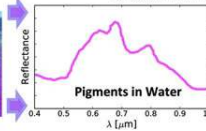
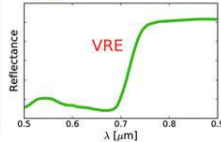
Photolytic Byproduct



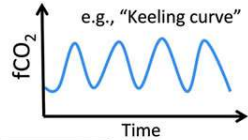
Surface



$$\text{NDVI} = \frac{\text{IR} - \text{VIS}}{\text{IR} + \text{VIS}}$$



Temporal

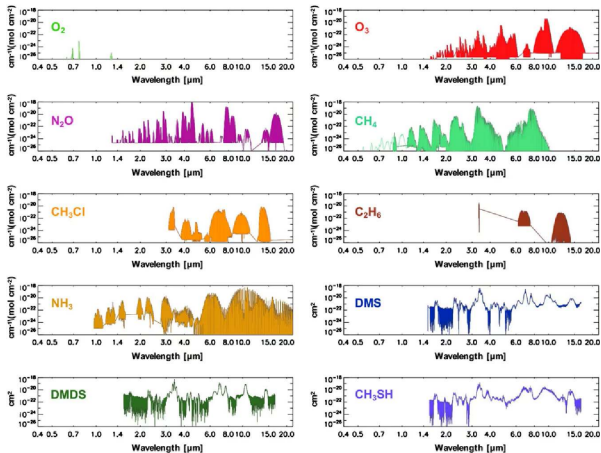


Seasonal
Changes in
Gases or
Surface



Three classes of biosignature. Schwieterman et al. (2018).

Gaseous (O_2 , O_3 , CH_4 , N_2O , organosulfur species), **surface** (the vegetation red edge near 700 nm) and **temporal** (seasonal cycles such as Earth's CO_2 Keeling oscillation): a credible detection needs several classes together.



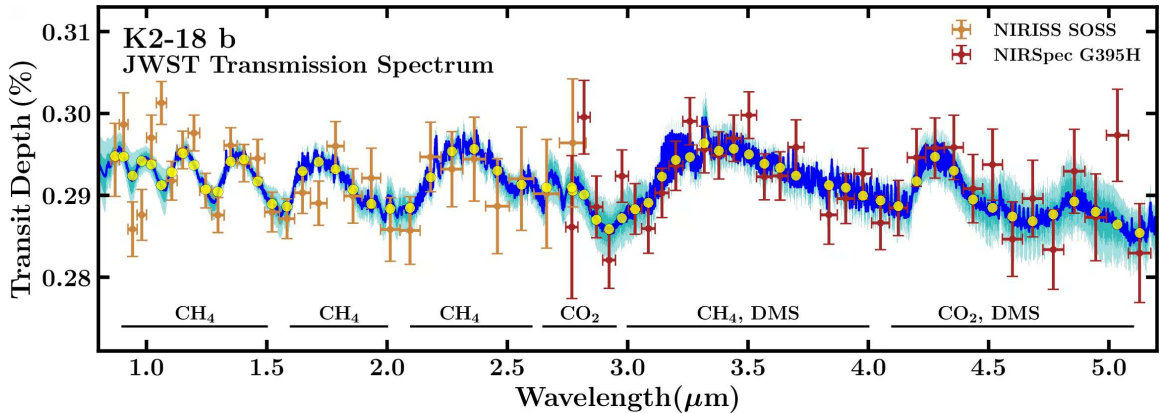
Mid-infrared bands of ten candidate biosignature gases. Schwieterman et al. (2018).

O₃ at 9.6 μm , CH₄ at 3.3 and 7.7 μm , N₂O and the DMS and DMDS window in 3–15 μm set the wavelength needs of LIFE (mid-IR interferometer) and HWO (Habitable Worlds Observatory).

Disequilibrium is the Diagnostic

- Individual gases in isolation almost always possess plausible abiotic origins
- Earth pair: O_2 (21%) and CH_4 (1.8 ppm) react on decade timescales
- Simultaneous persistence requires massive, continuous biological resupply fluxes

Chemically incompatible gases coexisting in an atmosphere are the most convincing remote signature of active biology.



JWST transmission spectrum of K2-18 b combining NIRISS and NIRSpect observations. Credit: Madhusudhan et al. (2023).

Absorption bands reveal atmospheric CH_4 and CO_2 alongside a tentative DMS feature near $3.4 \mu\text{m}$.

Catling 2018: A Bayesian Framework

EXOPLANET BIOSIGNATURES ASSESSMENT

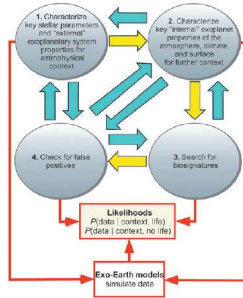
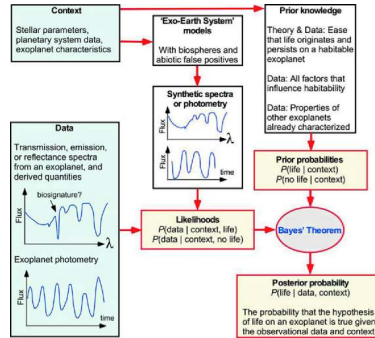


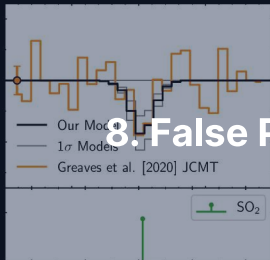
FIG. 2. Four components to assess whether a planet



Detection is a Bayesian chain of inference over stellar context, planetary properties and abiotic mechanisms, not a single yes/no spectral peak.

Source: Catling et al. (2018)

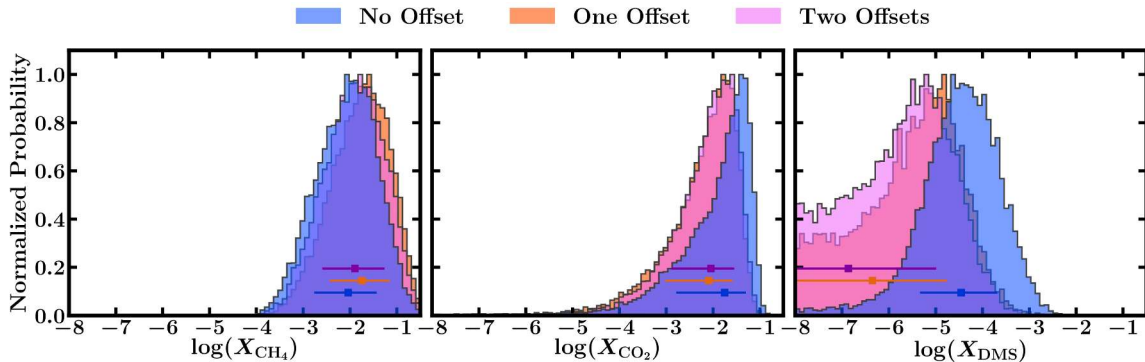
8. False Positives and Solar System Targets



False Positives: Every Gas Has an Abiotic Pathway

- Abiotic O_2 : H_2O photolysis followed by hydrogen escape, or CO_2 photolysis
- Abiotic CH_4 : hydrothermal serpentinisation or volcanic outgassing at low oxygen fugacity
- Abiotic N_2O from lightning and photochemistry; DMS has no significant abiotic Earth source, but one could exist elsewhere

Verification is an inverse problem: confirmation requires ruling out every plausible geochemical and photochemical false positive.



Retrieved mixing ratio posteriors for CH_4 , CO_2 and DMS in K2-18 b under zero, one and two floating instrument offsets. Credit: Madhusudhan et al. (2023).

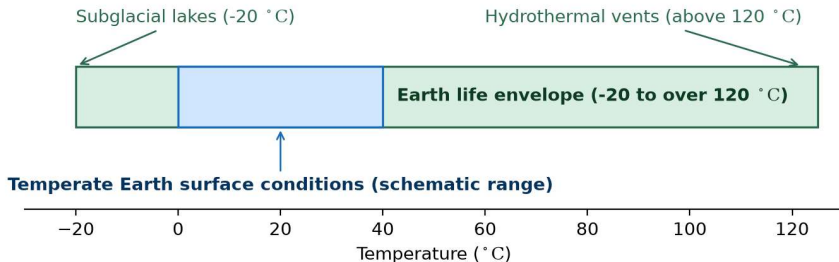
CH_4 and CO_2 hold under every offset choice, while the DMS significance collapses from 2.4σ to below 1σ .

Solar System Targets for Life Detection

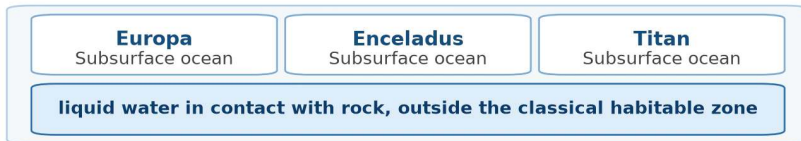
- Mars: ancient habitable lacustrine environments; the Mars Sample Return path
- Europa and Enceladus: confirmed subsurface oceans; Enceladus's plume carries H_2 , organics and phosphates from hydrothermal activity, hypothesised for Europa
- Titan and Venus: complex hydrocarbon hydrology and contested cloud chemistry

Five prime environments with liquid water reservoirs or rich organic chemistry.

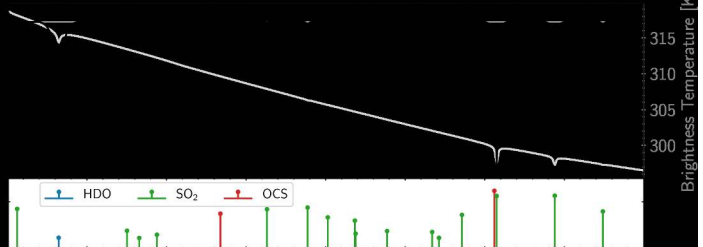
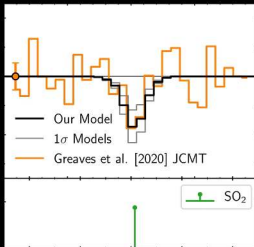
(a) Earth life temperature envelope (schematic)



(b) Icy-moon ocean worlds (schematic)

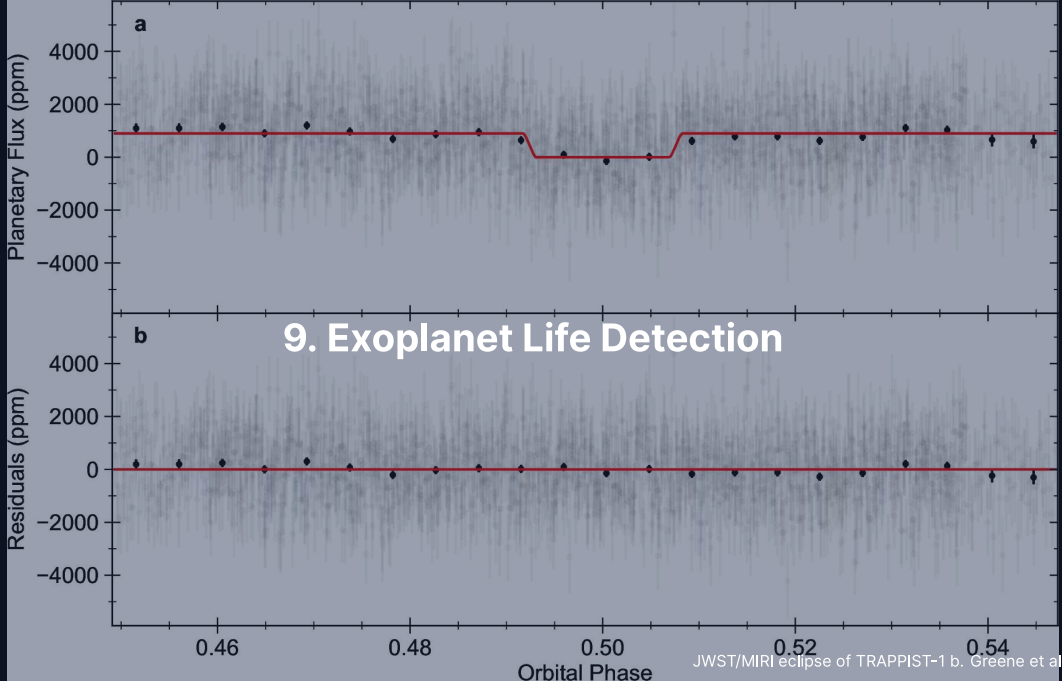


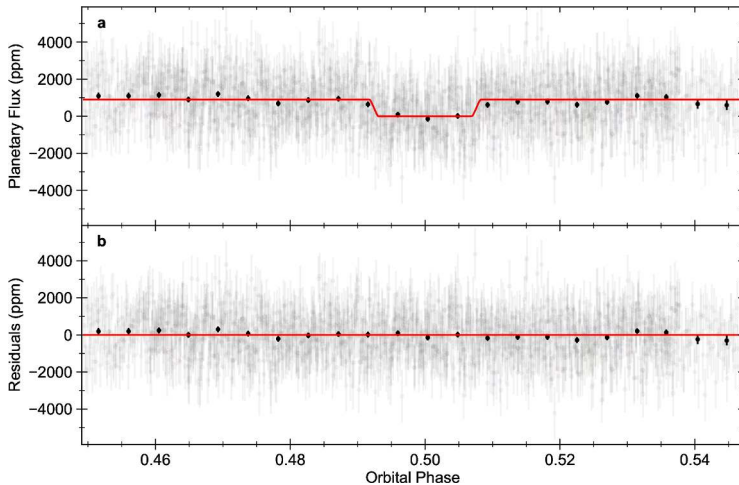
Extremophiles widen the definition of habitable: Earth life spans -20 to over 120 °C, and the icy moons hold liquid water in contact with rock outside the classical habitable zone. Course figure.



The Venus phosphine controversy: the claimed PH_3 line against the mesospheric SO_2 fit.
Lincowski et al. (2021).

Greaves et al. (2021) claimed PH_3 in the Venus clouds, but the line is fit by SO_2 ; K2-18 b teaches the same lesson (CH_4 at 5σ and CO_2 at 3σ stand, DMS fell from 2.4σ to $\sim 1\sigma$); DAVINCI tests Venus in situ, EnVision and VERITAS from orbit.

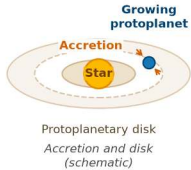




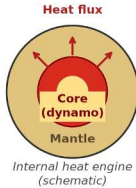
JWST MIRI 15 μm secondary eclipse of TRAPPIST-1 b. Credit: Greene et al. (2023).

The dayside brightness temperature of 503 K matches the 508 K bare-rock prediction and rules out a thick atmosphere.

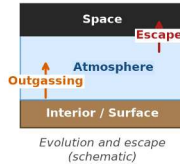
(a) Planet formation



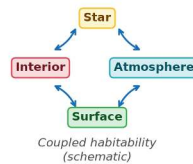
(b) Planetary interiors



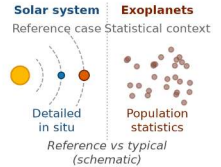
(c) Atmospheres



(d) Habitability



(e) The solar system



The five biggest lessons: formation, interiors as heat engines, dynamic atmospheres, habitability as a coupled property, the solar system as reference case. Course figure.

Open question

What is at stake, and what will decide it

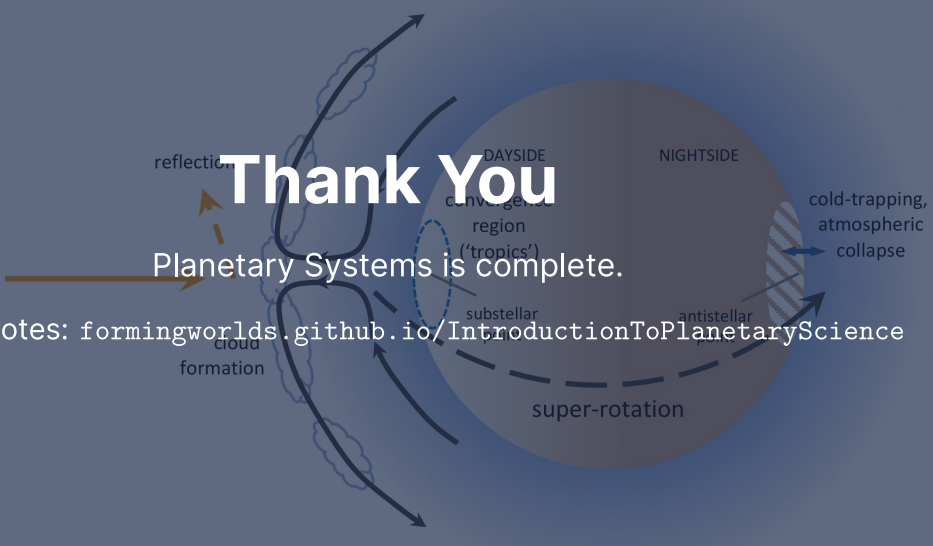
1	Is the origin of life a rare accident or a generic chemical inevitability?	→	The largest uncertainty in quantitative habitability estimates
2	What carves the radius valley between super-Earths and sub-Neptunes?	→	Photoevaporation, core-powered mass loss, or distinct formation channels
3	When did Jupiter form?	→	Architect of the inner solar system: the NC-CC dichotomy and Earth-like system rarity
4	Was Mars ever inhabited?	→	Mars Sample Return, the most direct test; it recalibrates the prior on f_l
5	Is the solar system rare or typical?	→	PLATO, Gaia DR4/DR5 and long-baseline RV give a probabilistic answer

The five biggest open questions, each with what is at stake or the test that will decide it.
Course figure.

Summary

1. Planet formation and differentiation are universal physical processes; interiors are heat engines that drive tectonics, dynamos and outgassing over Gyr
2. Atmospheres evolve through escape, outgassing and photochemistry, and habitability is a coupled trajectory, not a static orbital condition
3. The solar system is one detailed reference in a diverse exoplanet population

Next: The final exam.



A diagram of a planet with various atmospheric features labeled. On the left, a sun icon emits a horizontal arrow towards the planet. The planet is divided into a 'DAYSIDE' (left) and a 'NIGHTSIDE' (right). On the dayside, there is a 'convergence region ('tropics')' marked with a dashed blue circle, and 'cloud formation' is indicated by blue cloud shapes. An arrow labeled 'reflection' points away from the dayside. On the nightside, a dashed blue circle marks the 'antistellar point', and a blue arrow points to a hatched area labeled 'cold-trapping, atmospheric collapse'. A dashed blue line at the bottom indicates 'super-rotation'. Curved black arrows show atmospheric circulation from the dayside to the nightside.

Thank You

Planetary Systems is complete.

Lecture notes: formingworlds.github.io/IntroductionToPlanetaryScience